9, and its main objective was to secure the roads that linked Tel Aviv and Jerusalem. The first phase was an attack on two towns close to the road, Lydda and Ramle, both of which were defended by units of the Arab Legion and local armed militia units. Lydda was attacked first in the first multi-brigade operation conducted by the IDF. The city was taken on July 11 at a cost of fewer than 10 IDF troops (the defenders were estimated to have lost over 400 casualties). The following day, Ramle was taken. On July 13, the IDF oversaw a forced expulsion of the whole Arab civilian population in Lydda and Ramle. Without transport, these people—numbering close to 60,000—were forced to trek along the dusty roads on foot, and some (the exact number remains a matter of debate) died from exhaustion and dehydration as a result.

Two days later, on July 15, IDF forces mounted another series of attacks on the fortress of Latrun, still occupied by troops of the Arab Legion. Even though the attack was supported by the two Cromwell tanks stolen from the British Army, the Israelis failed to take the fortress. Meanwhile, in Jerusalem, members of Lehi and Irgun attempted to take back control of the Old City. After two days of fighting, on July 16 and 17, they were forced to break off this attack and return to their starting positions. In Eastern Galilee, Operation Brosh was an attempt to force Syrian forces to withdraw from the area of the Benot Yaakov Bridge. This too was a failure that left 100 IDF troops (and around 200 Syrians) dead.

The most successful IDF action during this phase of the war was Operation Dekel, which began on July 8 and involved an assault in Southern Galilee intended to take control of the town of Nazareth and the Lower Galilee area. By July 15, IDF forces had taken Nazareth and were in control of much of the surrounding area. Defending forces, mainly members of local militias, were forced to flee to the hills.

Generally, the second phase of the war—the Ten-Day Battles—was very different from the first. In the first phase, the IDF had defended against the advancing Arab armies. In this second phase, it was oftentimes the IDF advancing while Arab forces defended. In the first phase of the war, the IDF had barely managed to hold out against larger and better-equipped Arab forces. In this second phase, the forces of the IDF were larger and better equipped, though they